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Extending the Value Proposition Canvas to Support Customer-Centric Transition in a B2B2C Technology Organization

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Abstract: Technology-driven companies often express a strategic ambition toward customer-centricity, but struggle to translate it into operational practices such as solution discovery. In business-to-business-to-consumer (B2B2C) ecosystems, where organizations reach end-customers indirectly through business partners, commonly used design tools such as the Strategyzer Value Proposition Canvas offer limited guidance. While solutions in these contexts should be shaped by customer insights, internal limitations and partner-imposed pressures often override them. This paper presents a practice-based case study of how the Value Proposition Canvas was extended within a cybersecurity organization undergoing a customer-centric transformation. Following a research-through-design approach, the canvas was iteratively refined through co-creation workshops and reflection. The final version incorporates internal and partner pressures, desired customer behaviours, explicit opportunity framing, a user story element, and early acceptance criteria. The findings show how the extended canvas helps teams move from strategic intent to concrete, customer-informed solution definition in complex B2B2C environments.

Keywords: Value Proposition Canvas, Customer-centricity, B2B2C, Solution Discovery, Research-through-Design

1 Introduction

Many technology-driven organizations articulate a strategic ambition to become more customer-centric, as prior research has shown that customer-centricity is associated with sustained competitive advantage, stronger customer relationships, and improved long-term performance (Shah et al., 2006; Hemel & Rademakers, 2016). However, achieving this ambition is not easy. Even when customer-centricity is defined at a strategic level, it rarely reaches operational practices. Internal priorities, technical constraints, and commercial objectives continue to shape how teams actually work (Hemel & Rademakers, 2016; Shah et al., 2006).

These tensions are more evident in business-to-business-to-consumer (B2B2C) contexts. In this model, an organization (the first B) delivers its solution to end-customers indirectly through business partners (the second B), such as telecom operators or internet service providers. Companies often choose this model to reach a broader customer base through established distribution channels.

However, this indirect access introduces specific challenges. First, the organization has limited visibility into end-customer needs, since partners mediate the relationship. Second, partners bring their own commercial demands that may not align with end-customer value. Third, the organization's own internal constraints further shape what can realistically be developed. As a result, customer insights are frequently compromised by these competing forces, leading to fragmented solution discovery (Shah et al., 2006; Hemel & Rademakers, 2016).

Design tools and canvases are used to structure early-stage problem exploration and build shared understanding across multidisciplinary teams (Stickdorn et al., 2018). Among these, the Strategyzer Value Proposition Canvas is commonly used to articulate customer needs, pains, and gains (Osterwalder et al., 2014). Yet, the canvas provides limited support for solution discovery in complex organizational environments such as B2B2C.

This paper presents a case study of an extended Value Proposition Canvas developed within F-Secure Corporation (F-Secure, n.d.), a cybersecurity organization operating in a B2B2C context whose strategic vision centres on security experience, positioning customer-centricity as a core organizational priority. The research focuses on the perspective of the first B (the technology organization) and how it can maintain customer-centricity within these constraints. Following a research-through-design approach (Zimmerman et al., 2007), the canvas was iteratively refined through co-creation workshops and ongoing reflection to better support solution discovery under organizational constraints.

This study investigates how adapting a context-specific design artifact can support customer-centric solution discovery in a B2B2C organization. The extended Value Proposition Canvas adds elements that make internal and partner pressures visible and guide teams to define solutions that move customers toward the intended “best behaviour”. These changes support solution discovery that creates meaningful customer value while remaining realistic within internal and partner constraints.

2 Theoretical Background

This section provides the key concepts that guide the study. It explains the shift toward customer-centricity in organizations. The Double Diamond and Triple Diamond are presented as process models that help structure customer understanding within product and strategy work. The Strategyzer Value Proposition Canvas is then reviewed as the foundation for the extended canvas developed and evaluated in this study. Together, these concepts provide the context and reasoning behind the research.

2.1 Customer Centricity as Organizational Transformation

Historically, many organizations operate with a product-centric mindset, especially in the technology and manufacturing sectors. They are usually internally focused, prioritizing the efficient manufacturing and delivery of high-quality products over understanding the needs and experiences of customers or end-users (Hemel & Rademakers, 2016). While this approach often produces technically excellent outcomes, it also creates blind spots. Product decisions are misaligned with what customers value, causing wasted resources, low engagement, increased churn, or dissatisfaction.

In response, many companies started to shift toward customer centricity, a strategic reorientation described by Hemel and Rademakers (2016, p. 3) as "placing value creation for the customer at the core of key business and organizational processes." Similarly, Shah et al. (2006, p. 4) emphasize that in customer-centric firms, "every decision begins with the customer and anticipated opportunities for advantage." This shift is both a mindset and an operational transformation, where the customer, rather than the product, becomes the central focus of decision-making.

Customer-centricity requires more than just rethinking how sales and marketing are organized (Hemel and Rademakers, 2016). It requires aligning strategy, operations, and product development around customer value, representing both a cultural and structural shift within the organization.

2.2 Customer-Centric Processes

Customer-centricity should also be reflected in organizational processes. Research shows that customer-centric companies require structured mechanisms to generate and embed customer knowledge across functions (Hemel & Rademakers, 2016; Shah et al., 2006). Additionally, customer insights need to be considered in decision-making for product and strategy development. Without such mechanisms, solution discovery may become disconnected from actual customer needs.

This logic is reflected in process models such as the Double Diamond (Design Council, n.d.; 2023), illustrated in Figure 1, which separates problem exploration (Discover–Define) from solution development (Develop–Deliver). The Triple Diamond, as illustrated in Figure 2, introduces an earlier phase focused on opportunity identification and strategic alignment (Charak, 2020; Ulrich, 2020; Service Design Network, 2020). Both models emphasize that teams should first build a grounded understanding of customer needs and contextual factors before moving into solution development, whether at the feature, product, or strategic scale.

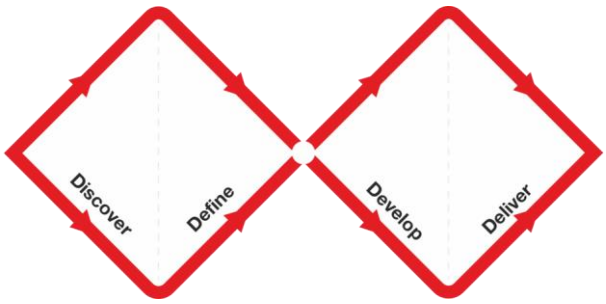


Figure 1. The Double Diamond design process, from Design Council (n.d.).



Figure 2. The Triple Diamond model, from Charak (2020).

This study focuses specifically on the solution discovery stage within such a customer-centric process.

2.3 Value Proposition Canvas and Its Limitations in Complex Contexts

The Value Proposition Canvas (VPC), developed by Osterwalder et al. (2014), as part of the Strategyzer framework and illustrated in Figure 3, is widely used to align products and services with customer jobs, pains, and gains. In this paper, the term Value Proposition Canvas (VPC) refers specifically to this Strategyzer model.

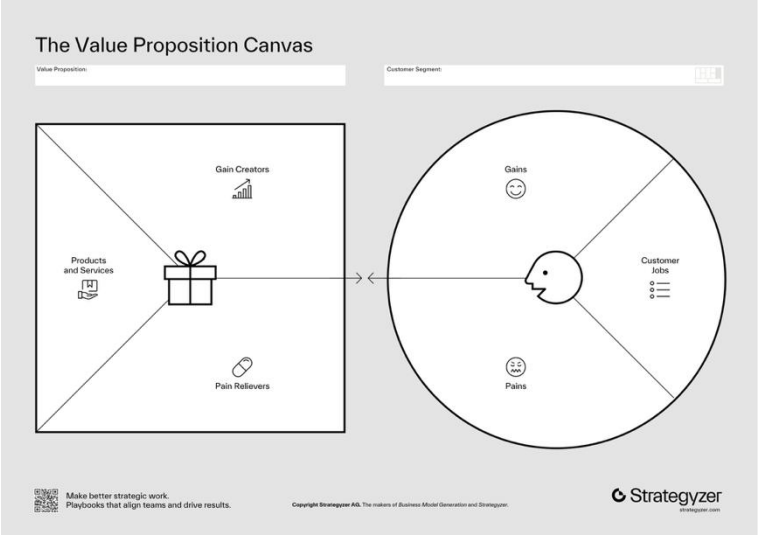


Figure 3, Value Proposition Canvas (Strategyzer, n.d.)

The VPC provides a structured way to define a customer value proposition, and it mainly centres around the insights coming from a customer segment, such as customer jobs, pains, and gains, which works well in B2B and B2C contexts. In B2C, the organization interacts directly with its end-customers, and in B2B, value is negotiated between two businesses with clear expectations on both sides.

However, in B2B2C settings, the end-customer is reached indirectly through a business partner, which creates layers between the organization and the customer it ultimately serves. Because of this indirect access, many factors come in between that can impact value delivery; partners bring their own commercial demands, internal teams face technical and resource constraints, and customer needs risk being pushed aside.

As a result, the VPC offers limited support for solution discovery in B2B2C settings, where feasibility, commercial demands, and organizational realities all influence what can be developed. This limitation motivates the extension presented in this study.

3 Research Context

This section describes the organizational context in which the study was conducted, including F-Secure's operating model, its customer-centric strategic ambition, and the introduction of the Triple Diamond process that frames the focus of this research.

3.1 Organizational Setting

This study was conducted within F-Secure Corporation, a global cybersecurity company operating in both B2C and B2B2C markets, as illustrated in Figure 4. While the research was not limited to a single business unit, early observations from a B2B2C-oriented unit highlighted systemic challenges in maintaining customer-centricity within solution development. In B2B2C contexts, end-customers are often reached indirectly through business partners such as telecom operators and internet service providers, which limits direct visibility into end-customer needs and experiences.

In this paper, the terms "end-customer" and "consumer" are used interchangeably to refer to the individual who ultimately uses the product. The canvas itself uses "consumer."

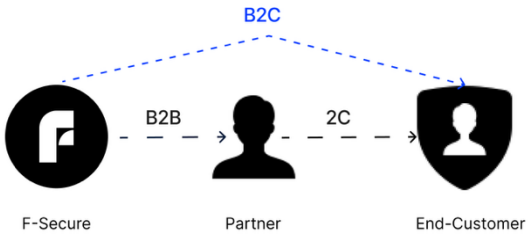


Figure 4, Showcasing B2B and B2B2C operating models at F-Secure

Across the organization, solution discovery is often influenced by internal roadmaps, technical feasibility considerations, and partner feature requests. While these priorities reflect valid business and operational concerns, they are not always grounded in validated end-customer insights. As a result, solution decisions sometimes focus more on internal alignment than on creating meaningful customer value.

3.2 Customer-Centric Transition and Triple Diamond Model Adoption

At the time of the study (2024), F-Secure's strategic vision was to become the number one security experience company in the world, which positioned customer-centricity as a central organizational ambition. To support this shift, the Triple Diamond model was gradually introduced as a guiding framework for product development and value creation across teams.

The first diamond (Opportunity Discovery) focused on collecting customer insights and uncovering opportunities that are strategically aligned with the organization's product direction and goals. The second diamond (Solution Discovery) aimed to shape solution concepts associated with selected opportunities. The third diamond addressed development and delivery.

While the new process was being adopted, practical mechanisms for sustaining customer focus during solution discovery remained underdeveloped. Discussions around solution discovery often shifted toward internal constraints or partner demands, increasing the risk that early solution reasoning drifted away from originally identified customer insights.

3.3 Focus of the Study

This study focuses on the Solution Discovery phase (Diamond 2), where teams explore and shape solution concepts based on customer insights and identified opportunities. The main challenge was to support teams in maintaining a customer-centric perspective while navigating internal constraints and partner-imposed pressures.

To address this, an extended Value Proposition Canvas was developed and iteratively refined as a structured artifact to guide co-creation and solution framing within this context.

4 Method

This study followed a research-through-design approach (Zimmerman et al., 2007), in which a design artifact is iteratively developed and refined as a means of generating knowledge. The extended Value Proposition Canvas functioned both as a practical tool during solution discovery and as the subject of investigation.

As an in-house Service Designer within the organization at the time of the study, the author was directly involved in facilitating co-creation workshops, conducting internal reflections, and iteratively testing the artifact in real project contexts. This setting enabled continuous observation of how the canvas influenced cross-functional discussions and decision-making during solution discovery.

4.1 Initial Design of Extended Canvas

The study started with the original Strategyzer Value Proposition Canvas used in a solution discovery workshop. In a B2B2C context, the limitations of the VPC, as discussed earlier, became evident. Therefore, the first extended version was designed to better reflect this complexity. Two key structural additions to the original VPC were introduced:

Pressures

During internal-stakeholder interviews conducted to understand the customer experience, participants were asked about customer pain points. However, instead of describing these pain points, many of the stakeholders started sharing their own operational frustrations and internal blockers. At first these comments were assumed to be irrelevant to the customer experience, but as it turned out, they revealed systemic constraints affecting the organization’s ability to address customer

needs. We collected and curated those insights and labelled them as “Pressures,” recognizing them as influential factors in solution discovery alongside customer needs, pain points, and gains.

Internal pressures within the company often result in customers’ pain points. As Nair (2018) notes companies often forget about the internal mechanisms that enable employees to deliver on the brand promise. Nair believed that “Pain points are many times self-inflicted within the corporation and impact the customer.” (2018, p.393).

Pressures are essential to solution discovery. They show us the real-world constraints that affect what can realistically be developed. This perspective is supported by innovation strategy theory. Jatin Desai (2014) describes two engines within organizations: (1) the mechanical engine, which is focused on operational efficiency, and (2) the innovation engine responsible for ideation, design, experimentation, and prototyping. If value proposition design is understood as part of the innovation engine, then we need guidance from the mechanical side.

At first, Pressures referred to only internal constraints, such as technical limitations, resource constraints, systemic inefficiencies and process gaps. Over time, it became evident that business demands imposed by partners also functioned as pressures, including expectations related to customer retention, competitive positioning, and revenue growth.

The introduction of “Pressures,” later redefined as internal and partner pressures, was the first addition to the extended Value Proposition Canvas.

Best Behaviour

During initial brainstorming sessions to shape the extended Value Proposition Canvas, it became clear that designing effective solutions is not only about addressing current pain points or amplifying current gains, but also about aligning solutions with long-term strategic intent.

Solution discovery usually begins from a current state in which customer needs are not met. At the same time, teams hold a vision of an ideal future state: a solution that meaningfully serves customers, reduces friction, and creates lasting value. However, internal or partner pressures often prevent immediate realization of this ideal state.

The introduction of “Best Behaviour” to the canvas addresses this gap. As illustrated in Figure 5, it acts as a directional guide, ensuring that even incremental solutions move toward the desired future state. By incorporating Best Behavior, the canvas creates space to evaluate solutions not only for current state but also for future expectations and strategic direction.

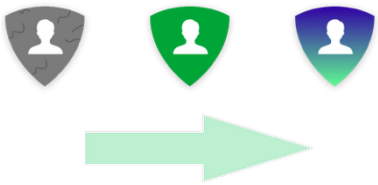


Figure 5, Progress from the current customer behavior toward the desired Best Behavior

4.2 Evaluation Process

Evaluation of the initial version of the extended Value Proposition Canvas was conducted through:

- Two internal co-creation workshops for different solution discovery projects, as summarized in Table 1. In both cases, the canvas was used as a shared framing tool to articulate customer needs, surface pressures, frame best behaviours, and shape early solution concepts.
- Internal reflection and design iteration after each workshop, including smaller sessions and informal discussions that revealed additional insights about how the canvas works in practice and its limitations.

Due to confidentiality constraints, detailed workshop content is reported at an abstract level.

Table 1. Overview of co-creation workshops

	Workshop 1	Workshop 2
Team	Direct Business team (the unit responsible for F-Secure's direct-to-consumer channel)	Design team (service, UX, and Visual designers)
Participants	15 participants (CX manager, business development lead, and other commercial stakeholders)	12 participants (service, UX, and Visual designers)
Goal	Address a recurring end-customer pain point that had been consistently reported through customer care channels	Enhance an existing product feature that a key business partner had requested in a more advanced form
Customer insights	Customer insights and a suggested best behaviour were pre-collected and written into canvas (participants reflected on individually as part of the session)	Heuristic, assumption-based (the team filled the customer insight boxes in the canvas relying on their existing product knowledge and domain experience, and then ideated solution concepts based on those assumption-based inputs)
Workshop format	Individual reflection on pre-filled canvas, Then small-group ideation around solution concepts and collecting potential pressures (facilitated by service designers)	Collaborative canvas filling (heuristic), Then ideation around solution concepts based on assumption-based inputs
Note	Although this workshop focused on the direct-to-consumer channel, the solution under discussion also affected the partner-distributed product, making the B2B2C dynamics relevant.	-

After each workshop, the canvas outputs were analyzed through a combination of thematic analysis and post-workshop reflection. The author also collected feedback from workshop participants on their experience using the canvas. These reflection sessions were informal and took place shortly after each workshop. They involved discussions with other designers to review the canvas outputs and identify what worked and where the canvas fell short. Separate conversations with members of the technology team also took place, particularly around the transition from solution discovery to development and delivery. Many of the structural findings described in the following section emerged from these post-workshop reflections rather than from the workshops themselves. Each analysis cycle led to revisions of the canvas.

5 Findings

The findings are grouped into two categories. (1) The first covers structural refinements to the extended Value Proposition Canvas, including new elements and adjustments. (2) The second category concerns the conditions required for the canvas to function effectively in practice.

5.1 Structural Refinements of the Extended Canvas

Opportunity Framing per Canvas

A major challenge across both workshops was overly broad scoping, which made ideation difficult to manage. A single canvas was initially used to capture all insights and solutions, but it quickly became overcrowded. Although a general scope was defined, it remained too wide, resulting in many ideas without a clear structure for organizing or following them up.

After analyzing the outcomes of each workshop, a pattern became evident: each solution concept aligned with a related cluster of pain points, and each cluster pointed to a specific underlying opportunity. The issue was therefore not the canvas itself, but the absence of a clearly defined opportunity per canvas.

Once each canvas was structured around a single focused opportunity, supported by its related customer insights, discussions became more manageable and the outputs easier to advance.

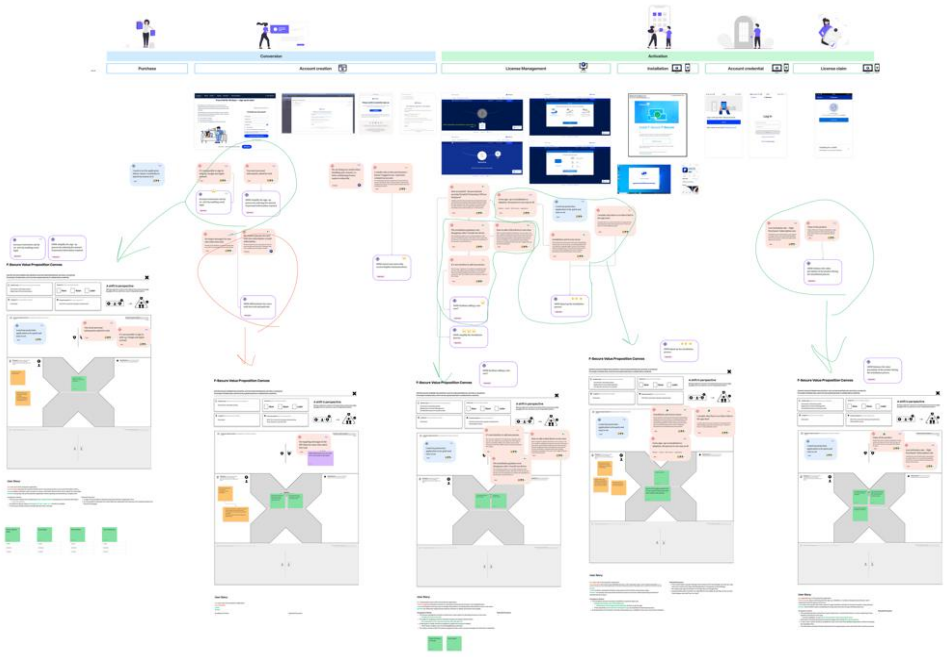


Figure 6, Clustering customer insight based on associated opportunities and linking the discovered solutions from Workshop to each cluster. Later, each cluster was mapped into one separated canvas.

Outcome Structuring: User Story and Early Acceptance Criteria

Across both workshops, the goal was to define solutions that create meaningful value for customers. While the canvas effectively supported insight gathering and co-creation, it lacked clarity regarding its expected output. The intention was to arrive at a draft of a solution concept, but the canvas did not provide a clear structure or format for articulating that outcome. As a result, both workshops' outcomes felt open-ended, consisting mainly of clustered insights and ideas without a concrete structure for taking the solution concept into the next step.

This limitation became more visible at the transition between solution discovery (Diamond 2) and solution design and development (Diamond 3). In practice, UI/UX designers, engineers and developers noted that when ideas entered Jira as product-driven tickets, the underlying customer context was often unclear. This created friction during feasibility assessment and early technical planning, as the “why” behind the solution was not consistently communicated.

To address this gap, two lightweight outcome elements were introduced. First, a high-level User Story was added on top of the canvas to consolidate the customer insights that were already captured in it into a single concise statement, making it easier to communicate the customer context alongside the solution concept. Second, optional Early Acceptance Criteria were added within the solution concept section to broadly describe what success might look like, without going into detailed requirements. These additions provide sufficient structure to support handover from exploration to execution.

Together, these refinements clarified the expected outcome of the canvas and strengthened continuity between solution discovery and development.

5.2 Conditions for Effective Use in Practice

Intentional Cross-Functional Inclusion

Sessions limited to a single discipline enabled fast and focused ideation, but they lacked sufficient challenge in other areas such as technical feasibility, business viability, or customer desirability. For example, the second workshop was conducted entirely among designers and clearly missed technical and business perspectives. Without input from those responsible for feasibility, delivery, and commercial impact, solution concepts remained conceptually strong but difficult to assess for implementation and far from reality.

At the same time, solution discovery sometimes addresses opportunities that span multiple parts of the customer lifecycle. In the first workshop, for instance, the scope covered a large portion of the customer journey before reaching the product (purchasing a subscription, downloading, installation, authentication, and onboarding). Such extensive opportunities

intersect with different product teams, technical components, and support functions. When the right stakeholders are not involved, solutions often lack clear ownership and are harder to implement.

These observations suggest that cross-functional collaboration is not only beneficial but necessary. For the canvas to function effectively, stakeholder participation must be intentionally aligned with the scope of the opportunity, ensuring representation from all relevant domains during co-creation.

5.3 Final Structural Extensions

In the final version of the Canvas, illustrated in Figure 7, the structural refinements described above were consolidated.

- A dedicated Opportunity section ensures focused scoping around a single opportunity and its related customer insights.
- A User Story at the top consolidates existing canvas insights into a concise statement to support handover into design and development.
- An optional Early Acceptance Criteria section under the Solution Concept offers a high-level description of intended outcomes.

Together, these refinements position the Canvas not only as a discovery tool but also as a structured bridge between strategy and delivery.

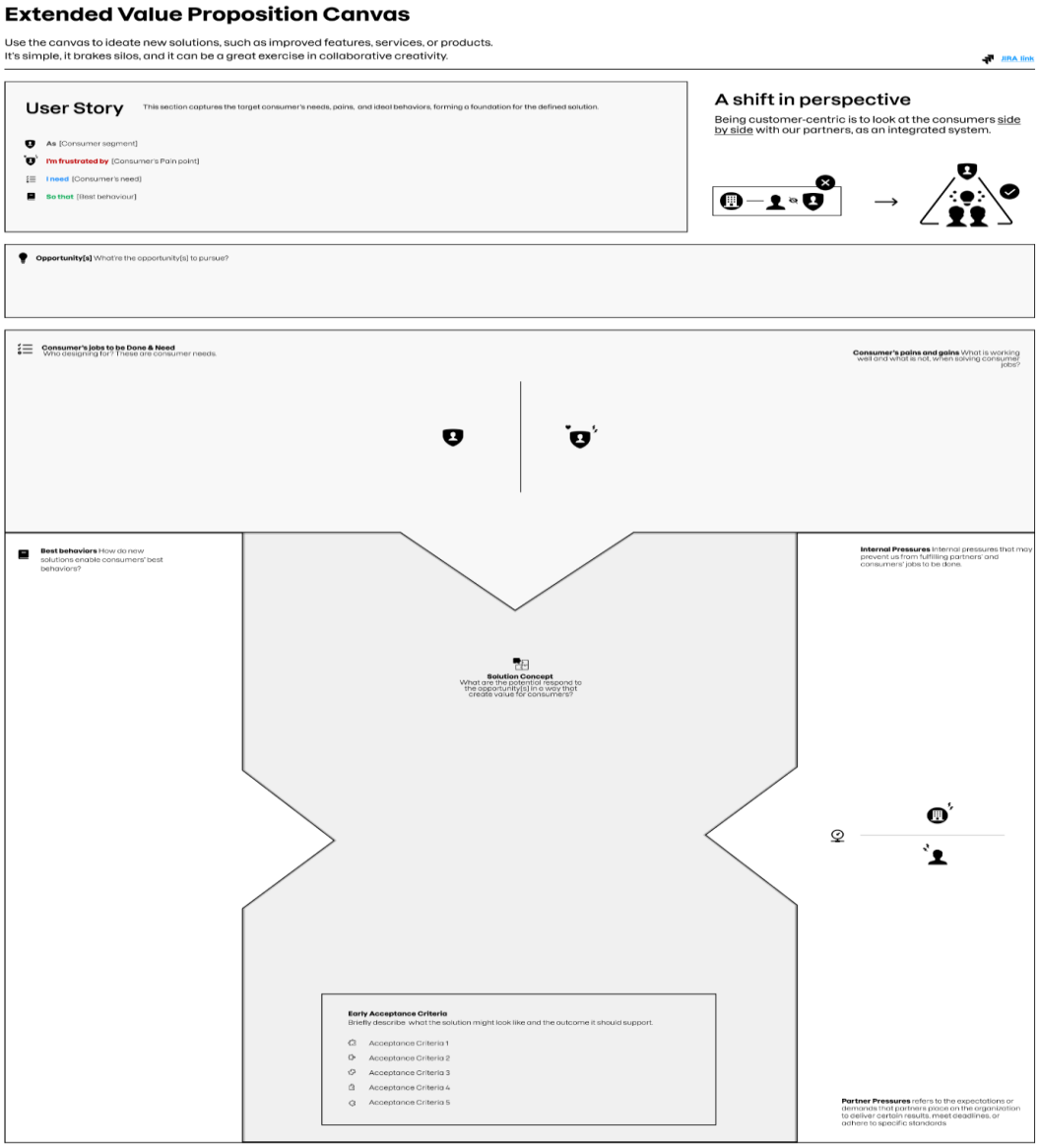


Figure 7, Extended Value Proposition Canvas

6 Discussion

This study shows that even when organizations adopt customer-centric processes and actively collect customer insights, this does not necessarily mean that those insights will resonate in the solutions explored to overcome customer needs and pains. Especially in complex B2B2C environments, where there are more layers between the organization and end-customers compared to B2C companies, solution discovery is shaped by multiple stakeholder forces, including internal limitations and partner-imposed pressures. Customer insight alone is therefore insufficient to ensure customer-aligned outcomes.

The extended Value Proposition Canvas functioned as a structured artifact that helped make these dynamics explicit. By requiring teams to define a focused opportunity connected with customer insights, articulate desired customer behaviour, and surface internal and partner pressures before diving into solution definition, the canvas guided solution reasoning in a more transparent and balanced way. Rather than allowing constraints to override customer value, it created space to negotiate them deliberately, so that the solution meets customer needs while remaining realistic within existing internal and partner pressures.

At the same time, the canvas is most effective when used in intentionally cross-functional settings. Different functions bring distinct knowledge, including technical feasibility, business constraints, and customer understanding. When these perspectives were not represented, solution concepts lacked realism or ownership. This suggests that both artifact structure and cross-functional collaboration are necessary conditions for effective solution discovery.

Finally, the addition of the User Story and Early Acceptance Criteria helped preserve continuity between discovery and development. By consolidating customer insights into a clear narrative and outlining intended outcomes at a high level, the canvas supported handover without losing the original customer reasoning. In this way, it functioned not only as a discovery tool but as a bridge connecting insight to implementation.

While each element of the extended canvas draws on established concepts from service design and agile practice, their integration into a single structured artifact offers a practical contribution to how organizations can operationalize customer-centricity in B2B2C solution discovery.

7 Conclusion

This study investigates how adapting a design artifact can support customer-centric solution discovery in a complex B2B2C organization. The findings show that customer-centricity cannot be sustained through process frameworks and insight collection alone. In multi-stakeholder environments, solution discovery is shaped by internal constraints and partner-imposed pressures that can dilute customer value.

The extended Value Proposition Canvas addressed this gap by structuring opportunity framing, making organizational pressures explicit, guiding teams toward desired future customer behaviour, and strengthening continuity between discovery and development.

Rather than replacing existing processes or introducing entirely new frameworks, the canvas supported more transparent and balanced solution reasoning by adapting a familiar tool to fit the organizational context (a practical way to embed customer-centric practices in complex settings).

This study is limited to a single organizational context, and the workshops did not include external partner participants. Future research could explore longitudinal adoption, broader partner involvement, and application across industries.

8 Acknowledgment

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